

One of the biggest arguments I hear for keeping a landline is for emergencies. When you dial 911 from a landline, the dispatcher can see your address right away. But when you call from a mobile device, the signal pings off of the closest cell tower, and takes much longer for the dispatcher to pinpoint an exact location. Even just a few seconds can feel like an eternity when you're facing an emergency.

If you have an elderly or disabled family member where 911 could be a real possibility, then by all means keep it, even if it's just for peace of mind. A very basic plan bundled with your cable and internet package is usually enough to get by. However, remember that when the power goes out, your phone will too, in which case you would have to use your cell. Weigh all the pros and cons, and decide whether or not a landline is completely necessary. For most phone users, it's not.

READER TIP:

I have a landline and no cell phone. It's \$20.39 a month including taxes. I don't have long distance, caller ID, or call waiting, but I DO have unlimited minutes. It's still much cheaper than having a cell phone.

—Brandy, ThePrudentHomemaker.com

2. NEGOTIATE A BETTER RATE

If you've read the last few chapters, you should know by now that negotiation is your best tool for a lower bill. You never know what deal you can get unless you ask, so don't be afraid to call and see what your phone company has to offer.

- Talk through different scenarios and compare the final cost. For example, what happens when you have less data or limited texting?
- Inquire about various company or employee discounts that may be available. Some companies offer up to 27% off your total bill, which adds up over time.